



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Lake Country Classical Academy
School Website: <https://www.lakecountryclassical.org>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Lake Country Classical Academy (LCCA) presents a clear orientation toward classical education, with manifest strengths in its mission, curriculum framing, and parent engagement. Public materials emphasize pursuit of truth, the love of beauty, and the formation of virtue, notably in statements about fostering moral character and civic virtue, and in a mission that foregrounds the flourishing of each student in heart and mind. The school identifies itself as Hillsdale College-aligned, describing Hillsdale as a partner that provides access to a classical curriculum and training, which signals alignment with a recognized classical framework and resources. There is also concrete evidence of robust parental involvement (e.g., parent book clubs and testimonials) and a commitment to civics and character formation. However, explicit, visible articulation of several core classical criteria—such as a named Great Books program and explicit use of Trivium/Quadrivium pedagogy, structured Socratic discourse in upper levels, and a formal “living curriculum” portrait of the teacher—are less clearly demonstrated in the public-facing materials. Taken together, these factors place the school firmly in the realm of CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with room to strengthen explicit articulation of several hallmark practices.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: - Make explicit on the website (Curriculum and Pedagogy pages) the presence of Great Books/Great Conversation, and any formal Trivium/Quadrivium elements in the lower and upper grades. - Elevate and publish explicit statements about Socratic dialogue, seminars, and other classical discussion formats (Paideia/Harkness-style practice) in the upper grades. - Feature a visible, written “Portrait of a Teacher” and a concise description of the living curriculum in action (how teachers embody and transmit the curriculum daily). - Expand liturgical or communal practices (even if nonsectarian, clearly articulate any liturgical rhythm, communal rituals, or shared cultural practices that align with the classical tradition). - Provide a clear, publicly accessible articulation of a pedagogy progression from K–8 to 9–12 that moves from contemplative/recollected learning (Scholé/restful days) to more rigorous rhetoric and public speaking, with concrete examples (speeches, debates, oratory opportunities). - Strengthen parent education offerings (e.g., more formal parent formation opportunities tied to classical education principles) and widen open-campus opportunities.

ABSTRACT Lake Country Classical Academy demonstrates a strong classical orientation anchored in truth, goodness, and beauty, with formation-focused goals and a Hillsdale-aligned curriculum. Public materials reveal clear commitments to character formation, civic virtue, and the flourishing of each student, along with active parent engagement. Core classical hallmarks such as Great Books, structured Socratic discourse, or explicit Trivium/Quadrivium pedagogy are less visible in public content, placing the school in a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL stance overall. Strengthening explicit articulation and implementation of Great Books/Great Conversation, Socratic pedagogy, and a visible living-curriculum portrait would push the school toward a CLASSICAL rating across more categories.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school speaks to formation of character and civic virtue, signaling engagement with transcendent ideals of truth, goodness, and beauty as central aims of education (e.g., “we nurture students in the pursuit of truth, the desire for good, and the love of beauty” and emphasis on moral character and civic

virtue). - Public materials describe Hillsdale-aligned curriculum and a classical orientation, which presumes alignment with a classical, virtue-centered frame of instruction and formation (e.g., “Lake Country Classical Academy is a Hillsdale College Member School” and its classical orientation).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness (desire for good), beauty (love of beauty), virtue (civic virtue), moral character. - Negative keywords observed: none detected in the public materials. - Count-based sense: at least five direct positive indicators (truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character/civic virtue) with no clear negative indicators found in the materials reviewed.

Why this rating - The textual emphasis on truth, virtue, and beauty, together with character formation and civic virtue, aligns with transcendental/metaphysical orientations characteristic of Classical education. The absence of explicit negative signals in this category reinforces a CLASSICAL alignment here.

Citations: “we nurture students in the pursuit of truth, the desire for good, and the love of beauty” and “moral character and civic virtue” ; Hillsdale affiliation signaling a classical/theological-intellectual underpinning within traditional Western-Christian educational streams.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements frame education as formation and the cultivation of virtue and human flourishing, not merely information or workforce prep. The mission explicitly references the flourishing of every student in heart and mind, and the core aims include truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, guiding the educational process (pursuit of truth, desire for good, love of beauty; formation in moral character and civic virtue; flourishing). - The school describes its aim as a classical education that forms character and civic virtue, aligning with paideia-type aims rather than a narrow workforce-preparation narrative. The public materials stress formation and moral education as core outcomes rather than job attainment alone (e.g., “teacher-led classical instruction in the liberal arts and sciences, with instruction in the principles of moral character and civic virtue” and mission-language about flourishing).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé, contemplation, great conversation, classical heritage, human excellence, soul craft, moral imagination, formation through the arts. - Negative keywords observed: explicit emphasis on “workforce readiness” or “21st-century skills” is not present; the direct counter-messages are not observed in the public content. - Count-based sense: multiple positive indicators aligned with classical formation and purposes; near-zero explicit negative indicators.

Why this rating - The emphasis on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the true/good/beautiful aligns strongly with Classical-schooled aims for education as formation, not just information or job prep.

Citations: mission-language: “flourishing of every student in both heart and mind”; “pursuit of truth, the desire for good, and the love of beauty”; “moral character and civic virtue”.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - LCCA positions itself as Hillsdale-supported and classroom instruction described as “classical” and “liberal arts and sciences,” which signals a classical curriculum orientation beyond standard public schooling. The Hillsdale partnership is explicitly stated as providing a classical orientation to curriculum and training. - Public materials include references to a Hillsdale-connected curriculum and a civics-centered formation; parent materials show engagement with traditional great-books-like readings in a family-education context (e.g., Parent Book Club discussing books tied to LCCA’s curriculum).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, classical curriculum, Great Books/Great Conversation (implied through Hillsdale classical approach and parent book club), formation through the arts, moral/ethic integration. - Negative keywords observed: Rather than direct negatives such as “project-based dominance” or “social studies rebranding of history,” the public content does not foreground such negatives; however, explicit mention of Great Books or the Trivium/Quadrivium is not consistently visible on public-facing pages in the excerpts reviewed (though implied through Hillsdale affiliation and

classic curriculum framing). - Count-based sense: 2–3 clear positive cues (liberal arts, classical curriculum, Great Books/Great Conversation implied via Hillsdale; plus a public emphasis on “pursuit of truth, beauty, and virtue”), with minimal explicit negatives. The visibility of Great Books and explicit Trivium/Quadrivium elements is not strongly demonstrated in the public corpus provided here, which yields a partial (SOMEWHAT) alignment.

Why this rating - Strong alignment in curriculum direction via “liberal arts and sciences” and Hillsdale posting, along with Great Books-oriented parent engagement. However, explicit, public-facing statements of Great Books as canonical text selections, explicit Trivium/Quadrivium usage, or a formal “Great Conversation” program are not clearly visible in the materials reviewed. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification rather than FULL CLASSICAL.

Citations: Hillsdale-member statement and classical framing (curriculum orientation) ; explicit formation and curriculum emphasis in mission and pedagogy language (teacher-led, liberal arts) ; Parent Book Club evidencing engagement with classical texts in practice.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe “teacher-led classical instruction in the liberal arts and sciences,” with emphasis on moral character and civic virtue as part of pedagogy (structure of classical instruction at least at the foundational level). - While the classical framework is asserted, explicit classroom practices such as Socratic seminars, exams in the style of a Harkness table, or routine use of memory work, singing/chanting, or Scholé days are not clearly spelled out in the public-facing materials. The lack of explicit mention of these traditional pedagogical modalities in public statements places the pedagogy in a guarded category, with some classical elements but incomplete articulation of hallmark methods.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed (from the Six Essential Elements Pedagogy vocabulary): Socratic dialogue, narration, chanting, singing to memorize, memory work, Scholé, rhythm of contemplative learning, seminars, rhetoric exercises (upper-level), etc. - Public materials show teacher-led instruction but do not closely enumerate these classical pedagogy terms; thus explicit positive signals are limited in the visible public content. - Negative keywords observed: explicit mention of “experiential learning focus,” “project-based only,” “student-directed” are not prevalent in the public materials; however, the explicit Pedagogy keywords for traditional classical pedagogy are not strongly enumerated.

Count-based sense: Visible positive pedagogical signaling is modest; explicit classic-pedagogy marker terms (Socratic, scholé, memory work, recitation, etc.) are not strongly evidenced in the public materials, leading to a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Why this rating - The school clearly operates within a classical pedagogy frame (teacher-led, liberal arts emphasis) but falls short on publicly asserting specific classical-method terms (e.g., Socratic seminars, scholé days, memory work) in accessible content. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, with potential to strengthen explicit pedagogy communications.

Citations: “teacher-led classical instruction in the liberal arts and sciences” (pedagogy anchor) ; absence of explicit Socratic/Scholé-language in the public-facing materials (inference from available text).

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements emphasize teachers as guides within a classical framework (e.g., “teacher-led classical instruction” and the broader aim of character formation), indicating a value placed on teachers as central to the living curriculum and the classical mission. However, explicit language describing teachers as “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” or a formal teacher-profile curation is not strongly visible in the excerpts reviewed. This suggests a classical orientation in practice, but a less explicit public articulation of faculty as the “living curriculum” or as a formal “portrait of what a teacher should be.”

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed (from the Six Elements’ Faculty vocabulary): living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, mentors, exemplars, teacher

training in classical pedagogy. - Public materials show “teacher-led” instruction and moral formation, but the explicit phrases above (living curriculum, portrait, etc.) are not strongly embedded in the publicly accessible text. The presence of “teacher-led” indicates a positive alignment to classical norms but not a full parade of “faculty as living curriculum.” - Negative keywords observed: none explicit in public materials.

Count-based sense: There is partial signaling of classical-faculty norms (teacher-led and moral formation) but not explicit articulation of a teacher-portrait or living-curriculum language, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL reading.

Why this rating - The emphasis on teachers as the mediators of a classical education (teacher-led instruction) aligns with classical norms, but the public text does not fully articulate the full “faculty as living curriculum” narrative or a formal teacher-portrait to the same degree as the strongest classical programs.

Citations: teacher-led instruction description ; explicit “living curriculum” or faculty-portrait language not clearly visible in the public materials (based on available public content).

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school actively partners with families and invites parental engagement in multiple ways. Public materials show parent-focused activities such as a Parent Book Club, including specific activities (the January Parent Book Club and Brave New World discussion) and parent testimonials praising the civics focus and the Hillsdale-based curriculum. This demonstrates robust parental involvement in the educational ecosystem and a view of parents as co-educators or engaged partners (e.g., “LCCA PARENT BOOK CLUB MEETING,” parent testimonials, and references to civics emphasis). - Enrollment language emphasizes accessibility and family involvement through open enrollment and family events; while not every community-engagement item is spelled out in the same section, the public-facing materials show a culture of welcoming parents and inviting them to school activities and visits (e.g., mentions of enrollment openness and events).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: Partnership with Families, formation of affections, love of learning, parent involvement in governance and education, parent book clubs, open campus/visits (as implied by accessible events and parent participation). - Negative keywords observed: None detected in public materials. - Count-based sense: Multiple explicit parental-engagement cues; no explicit negative signals.

Why this rating - The strongest category signal in the entire analysis is in Parents & Community, where explicit programmatic elements (Parent Book Club, testimonials emphasizing civics and curriculum, open invitation to parent involvement) strongly align with classical expectations of parent partnership and parental formation in the classical framework.

Citations: Parent Book Club details (scene of Brave New World reading and parent participation) ; parent testimonials and Hillsdale-curriculum framing indicating parental involvement and co-educator posture.

What Would Move the Needle

- If Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy) were to shift from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL, LCCA could explicitly publish and publicly document:
- A named Great Books program and a documented Great Conversation approach, with a clear year-by-year list of canonical texts and discussion formats.
- A public articulation of Trivium/Quadrivium elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) as part of the K–12 curriculum map.
- Clear statements about the use of Socratic dialogue or Harkness-style seminars in upper grades, with examples of weekly or monthly cycles of seminars and student-led discourse.
- Explicit “Scholé” days or contemplative learning cycles in Lower/Upper school and a public description of restful learning as a pedagogy component.
- A publicly accessible “Portrait of a Teacher” and description of the living curriculum: how faculty embody and transmit the curriculum, professional development in classical pedagogy, and a framework of teacher collaboration/mentoring.

- Element 5 (Faculty) could be strengthened by publishing a formal faculty-portrait page that describes the ideal teacher archetype in the school's Classical tradition and by detailing professional development in classical pedagogy.
- Element 6 already shows strong classical alignment; sustaining and expanding parent formation opportunities (e.g., regular book clubs, lectures, and family liturgical-type rhythms) would further consolidate CLASSICAL alignment.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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